Case Study: Redesigning IT Skills for Access, Confidence & Independence

A UDL informed digital learning redesign for a Youthreach classroom

Overview

This case study explores how I redesigned the delivery of three interconnected QQI Level 4 modules - Word Processing, Data Entry, and Information Technology Skills - to make digital learning more accessible for learners who are often brand new to computers. The redesign focused on simplifying access, building digital confidence, and creating a structure that supports continuous enrolment.

Context

In my centre, every learner receives a laptop and uses it across all subjects. For many, this is their first real experience using a computer. That means IT Skills isn't just another module - it's the foundation for everything else they do.

Before the redesign, learners struggled with:

- Finding their work
- Navigating Teams and OneNote
- Losing progress due to syncing issues
- Engaging with text-heavy reference materials
- Managing multiple overlapping assessments

Access, not ability, was the biggest barrier.

A Turning Point: New CAS Modules & MIMLOs

Just as I began the redesign, City of Dublin ETB updated several modules to a more modern format. This introduced Minimum Intended Learning Outcomes (MIMLOs) in place of the older, more rigid Learning Outcomes.

This shift gave me:

- More freedom to adapt materials
- Flexibility in how learners demonstrate skills
- Space to reduce duplication across modules
- A clearer foundation for UDL-aligned planning

The timing was perfect - the redesign and the new modules supported each other naturally.

Empathize	Define	Ideate	Prototype	Test
Research the Problem	Describe the Problem	Deliberate Solutions	Create Solutions	Put Solutions in Practice
• Learners can join the class partway through the year and feel intimidated if the rest of their group is too far ahead • Learners do not feel confident using a laptop or computer for basic tasks • Learners may not feel comfortable providing face to face feedback on the subject or class • Class materials are difficult to access and interact with	• Lecture based classes can be intimidating when starting somewhere new and leave a learner feeling left behind • Not having used a computer before leads to trepidation when using them for work • Not having an anonymous way to provide feedback can lead to annoyance with how the class operates • Struggling to access materials can lead to to annoyance and disengagement with the class	• Designing the course to be self-directed would allow for learners to join at any point and work to their skill level • Adding sections of work that focus solely on building digital literacy skills through practice and fun rather than as a separate time the learner is taken out of class may make using a computer less intimidating • Using an anonymous form at the end of each section will allow learners to provide feedback on what they have covered as they move through the course • Laying out materials in clear, easy to understand sections can help with finding what learners are working on, rather than navigating multiple menus	• Providing information in both plain text and colour rich formats will allow learners to choose the version they feel most comfortable • Collecting classwork using the built in Assignments in Teams will allow learners to see what work they need to do and move through it at their own pace • Creating an introduction module for the course will allow learners to practice and build digital literacy skills while completing tasks that will set up their computer for the duration of their time in the center • Using Teams Channels to lay out work means it will be on the first screen they see when opening the Team, rather than behind four screen as it currently is	• A new Class was created on teams that implements all of the ideas fro the previous section and used as the primary delivery method for all existing and new learners • Feedback was gathered as learners moved through the course and progress was gauged against learners who completed the same work last year using the original course layout • A record of any requested and necessary changes will be kept to be implemented before the next academic year

Above is the overall approach to the redesign through the lens of Design Thinking. This is a tool I have found extremely useful in anticipating learner needs when it comes to creating easily adapted coursework.

Design Goals

I set out to create a course that would:

- Be easy to navigate, even for complete beginners
- Support learners joining at any point in the year
- Build digital confidence through repetition and clarity
- Offer multiple ways to engage with materials
- Reduce frustration and increase independence
- Make space for external opportunities and authentic tech experiences

My Process

1. Mapping the Learning Outcomes & MIMLOs

I compared the older Learning Outcomes with the new MIMLOs to identify:

- Overlaps
- Skill duplication
- Natural progression points
- Opportunities for multimodal engagement

This helped me streamline the course into a clearer, more coherent pathway.

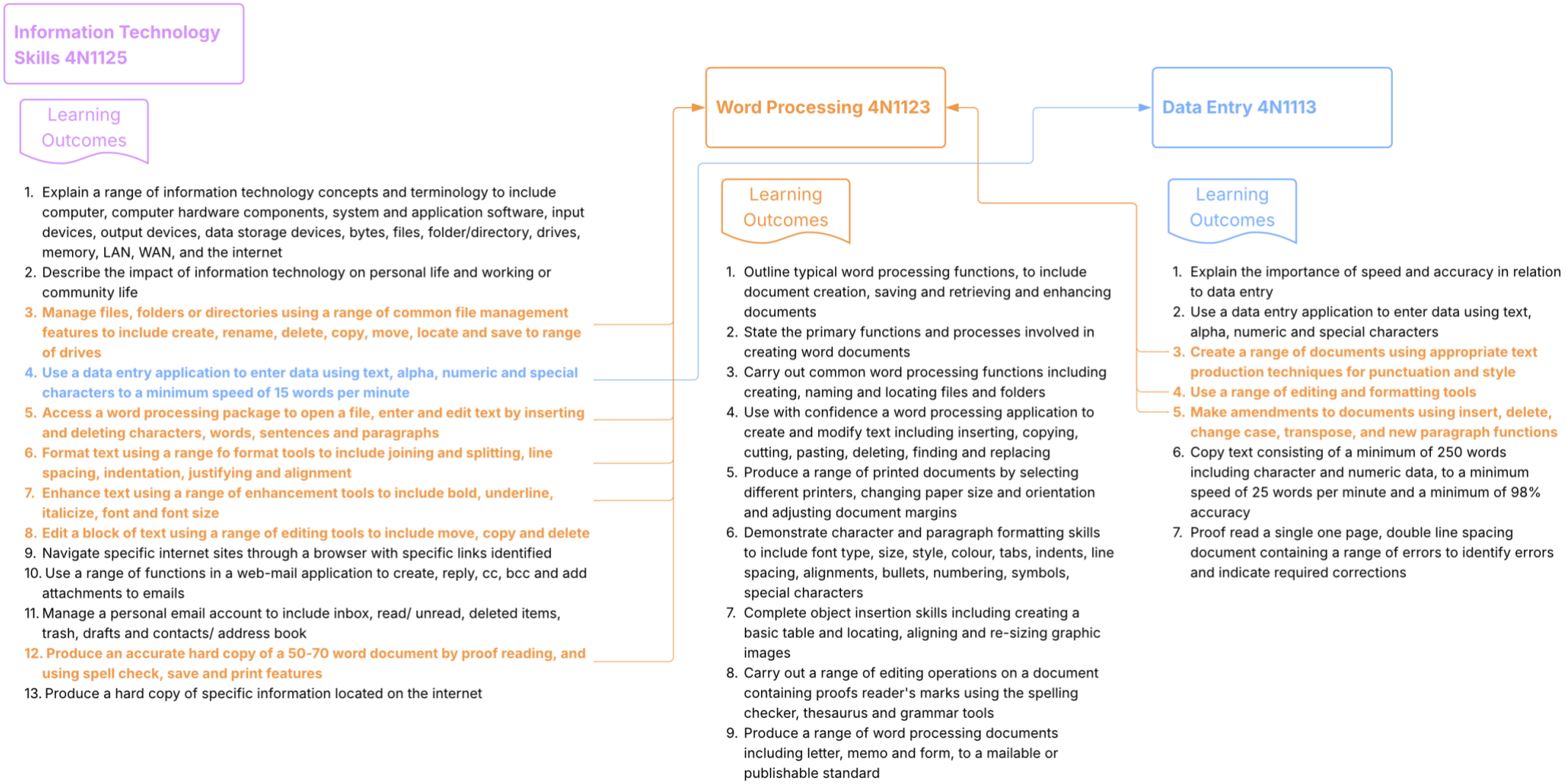
2. Rebuilding the Course Structure in Teams

I redesigned the Teams layout to be:

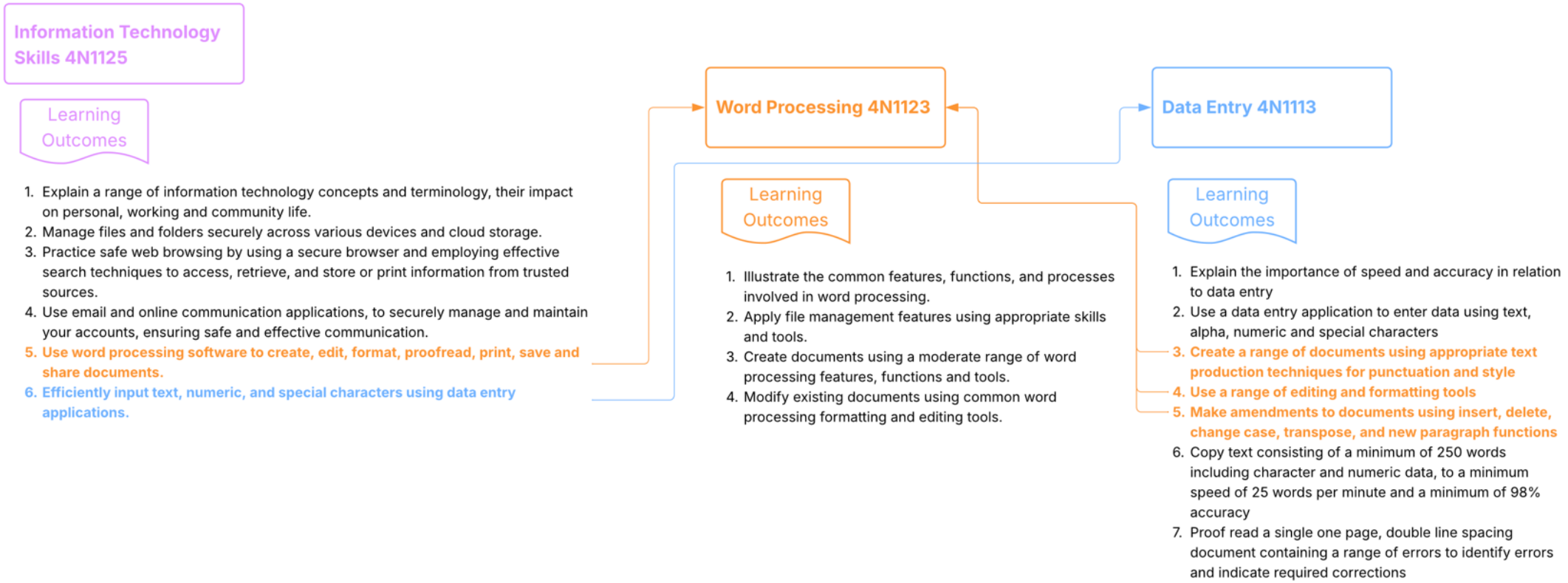
- Predictable
- Visually clear
- Easy to navigate
- Consistent across modules

Each module now has:

- A simple, colour-coded structure
- Step-by-step instructions
- Embedded videos
- Downloadable worksheets
- Clear “You are here” progress markers



Above is the original mapping of Learning Outcomes across my modules. Due to the number of LOs in each and the specificity of their goals it was difficult to ensure that they were mapped to each other in an efficient way.



Above show the mapping of Minimum Intended Learning Outcomes across the updated modules. The updated versions made it easier to map between courses and ensure that there was not over or under examining.

3. Applying UDL Principles Throughout

I used UDL to guide every decision, focusing on:

- Multiple Means of Engagement: videos, examples, group tasks, self-paced work
- Multiple Means of Representation: visuals, walkthroughs, templates, colour coding
- Multiple Means of Action & Expression: choice in how learners' complete tasks, flexible submission formats

4. Leaving Space for External Resources

I intentionally built the course so I could integrate opportunities from:

- Microsoft Dream Space (STEM Passport, Ambassador Programme)
- iDEA (micro-credentials learners can add to their CVs)
- CS Inc (Web Design & Development course)

These help learners see real pathways into tech and build confidence beyond the classroom.

5. Building a Bank of Optional Supports

To support differentiation, I maintain a growing library of:

- Step-by-step guides
- Extra practice tasks
- Video walkthroughs
- Alternative worksheets
- Reference sheets

Learners can access these whenever they need them, without stigma.

Impact

Learners

- Navigate Teams more independently
- Engage more with instructional videos
- Complete more non-summative work
- Show stronger performance in formative assessments
- Report feeling more confident using their laptops across all subjects

Colleagues

- Have asked for help updating their own courses
- Noted improved learner confidence and independence
- Adopted elements of the redesigned structure in their own modules

What I Learned

- Access is the foundation of engagement
- Predictability reduces anxiety for learners new to digital tools
- UDL isn't an add-on, it's a core part of designing a curriculum
- Small design decisions (colour coding, layout, naming conventions) make a big difference
- Learner feedback is essential for iterative improvement
- Flexibility in assessment (thanks to MIMLOs) opens the door to more authentic learning